

ZOKARIO EDITIONS

The Compound Path

*Patience as a strategy: investing principles
for people playing the long game.*

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The Eighth Wonder, Slowly

There is a famous illustration of compounding involving a chessboard and grains of rice: one grain on the first square, two on the second, doubling on and on until the final squares require more rice than the planet grows. It is mathematically true, universally quoted, and it has taught almost nobody anything, because the human mind files it under 'clever' rather than 'urgent'.

Here is the version that changes behaviour. Two people begin working at twenty-five. The first invests steadily for ten years and then, life happening, never adds another unit. The second waits those same ten years, then invests the identical amount every year for thirty. The first person, who stopped, very often ends with more. Not because of skill. Because their money was in the room a decade earlier, and in compounding, being early is a bigger advantage than being clever, disciplined, or even rich.

Every useful investing behaviour follows from actually believing that paragraph: not admiring it, believing it, the way you believe in gravity when standing near an edge. The rest of this book is an attempt to move compounding from the part of your mind that admires ideas to the part that flinches near edges.

We start with the only variable that is fully yours: your own behaviour.

Your Behaviour Is the Portfolio

Decades of investor-return studies converge on an awkward finding: the average investor reliably underperforms the average investment, often by more than fees and inflation combined. The gap has a single cause: buying after rises and selling after falls, at the exact moments feeling and wisdom point in opposite directions.

This chapter is a guided tour of your own likely mistakes: loss aversion, recency, the itch to act. The aim is not to shame them but to design around them. You cannot remove the flinch. You can build a portfolio the flinch cannot reach.



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